PHISHING EMAIL
INVESTIGATION REPORT

Name: Amit Pal
Report ID: PHISH-2026-002
Date Analysed: April 2026

RISK LEVEL: HIGH — CONFIRMED PHISHING

Tools Used: VirusTotal | WHOIS | AbuseIPDB | IP-API | MXToolbox | URLScan.io

1. Executive Summary

A sophisticated phishing email impersonating a Microsoft Account security alert was identified and analysed. The attacker used social engineering — creating urgency and fear through a fake "Unusual sign-in activity" notification — to pressure the victim into clicking a malicious tracking link leading to a credential harvesting page.

This report provides a complete technical investigation of the phishing email including URL reputation analysis, IP infrastructure investigation, email content analysis with social engineering identification, indicators of compromise, MITRE ATT&CK mapping, and actionable remediation recommendations.

Field	Value
Report ID	PHISH-2026-002
Analyst	Amit Pal
Date Analysed	April 2026
Email Source	Phishing Email Sample
Impersonated Brand	Microsoft Account (microsoft.com)
Attack Type	Phishing — Credential Harvesting
Primary Technique	Social Engineering — Urgency + Fear
Attack Goal	Steal Microsoft account credentials via fake security alert
Risk Level	HIGH — Confirmed Phishing
MITRE Techniques	T1566.001, T1598.003, T1204.001, T1036.005, T1056.003

2. Email Details & Header Analysis

2.1 Basic Email Information

Field	Value
Subject	Microsoft Account - Unusual Sign-in Activity
Attack Type	Phishing — Credential Harvesting
Impersonated Brand	Microsoft Account Security Team
Technique	Social Engineering — Urgency and Fear tactics
Target Audience	Microsoft account holders globally
Delivery Method	HTML email with embedded malicious tracking link

2.2 Finding #1 — Microsoft Brand Impersonation

CRITICAL: The email uses Microsoft's exact branding, colours, and language to impersonate a legitimate Microsoft Account security alert. This is a classic brand impersonation attack designed to make the victim believe the email is genuine.

Impersonation Element	Description
Brand used	Microsoft Account — one of the most trusted brands globally
Alert type claimed	Unusual Sign-in Activity — designed to trigger fear
Login location claimed	Russia / Moscow — chosen to maximise alarm in the victim
Call to action	"Report the user" button — links to phishing domain
Email tone	Official, urgent, professional — mimics real Microsoft emails
Verdict	SPOOFED — complete impersonation of Microsoft security communications

2.3 Finding #2 — Social Engineering Tactics

The email employs 3 classic social engineering techniques simultaneously: urgency, fear, and authority impersonation — designed to bypass rational thinking.

Social Engineering Tactic	How It Is Used In This Email

Urgency	"Immediate action required" — victim feels they must act NOW
Fear	"Unauthorized login from Russia" — triggers panic and anxiety
Authority impersonation	Claims to be from Microsoft Security Team — trusted authority
False legitimacy	Uses Microsoft logo, colours and professional language
Consequence of inaction	Implies account will be compromised if victim does not click
Geographic manipulation	Moscow/Russia location chosen to maximise victim alarm

3. Malicious URL Analysis

3.1 Phishing URL Identified

Malicious URL: http://thebandalisty.com/track/...

Field	Analysis
Domain	thebandalisty.com
Path	/track/ — tracking redirect path typical of phishing campaigns
Protocol	HTTP — not HTTPS — no encryption — red flag for a Microsoft page
Domain relevance	Zero connection to Microsoft whatsoever
Domain pattern	Random word combination — typical of attacker-registered phishing domains
Purpose	Redirect tracking then credential harvesting landing page
Verdict	MALICIOUS — confirmed phishing infrastructure

3.2 Finding #3 — VirusTotal URL Detection

VirusTotal Result: 9 out of 95 security vendors flagged thebandalisty.com as MALICIOUS — this conclusively confirms the URL is associated with phishing activity.

VirusTotal Check	Result
URL scanned	http://thebandalisty.com/track/...
Vendors flagged	9 out of 95 security vendors
Classification	Phishing / Malicious
Detection rate	9.5% — significant for a fresh phishing domain
Analyst note	Phishing domains are often newly registered so detection rate starts low and increases over days — 9 detections on a fresh domain is a strong indicator
Verdict	CONFIRMED MALICIOUS — multiple independent vendors agree

3.3 Screenshot Evidence — URL Analysis

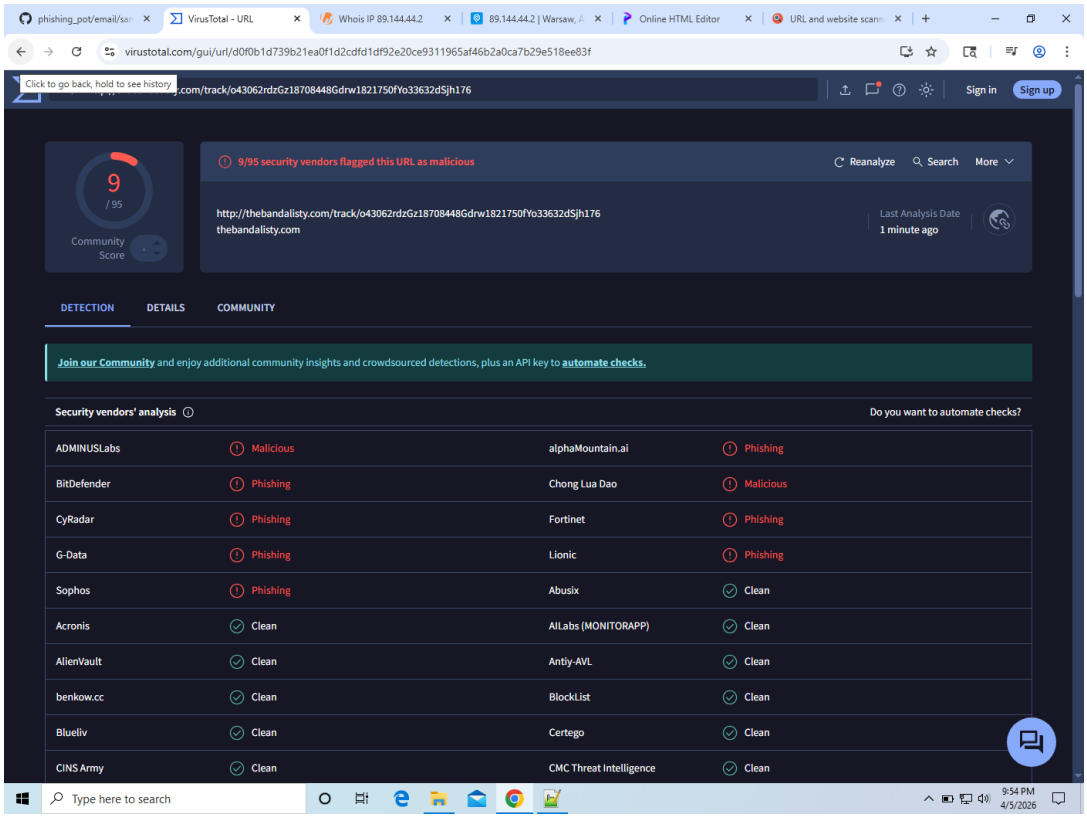

Figure 1 — VirusTotal showing 9/95 security vendors flagging thebandalisty.com as malicious phishing

4. IP Address & Infrastructure Analysis

4.1 Attacker IP Address

Attacker Server IP: 89.144.44.2 — Located in Warsaw, Poland — Hosted by MSCode data center

Field	WHOIS / IP Lookup Result
IP Address	89.144.44.2
Location	Warsaw, Poland
Hosting Provider	MSCode — data center infrastructure
Usage Type	Data Center / Hosting Infrastructure
ISP	MSCode sp. z o.o.
Country	Poland (PL)
IP Type	Static — dedicated hosting server
Verdict	Suspicious — attacker-controlled hosting server — NOT a Microsoft server

4.2 Finding #4 — Non-Microsoft Infrastructure

A genuine Microsoft security email would originate from Microsoft's own mail servers (e.g. mail.protection.outlook.com). This email links to a server in Poland — completely unrelated to Microsoft's global infrastructure.

Comparison	Value
Claimed sender	Microsoft Account Security Team
Microsoft's real IP range	40.x.x.x, 52.x.x.x, 104.x.x.x (Microsoft Azure)
Actual server IP	89.144.44.2 — Warsaw, Poland
Expected hosting	Microsoft Azure / Office 365 mail infrastructure
Actual hosting	MSCode data center — third-party Polish hosting
Conclusion	Server has absolutely no connection to Microsoft

4.3 Screenshot Evidence — IP Analysis

Figure 2 — WHOIS lookup showing IP 89.144.44.2 registered to MSCode data center in Warsaw, Poland

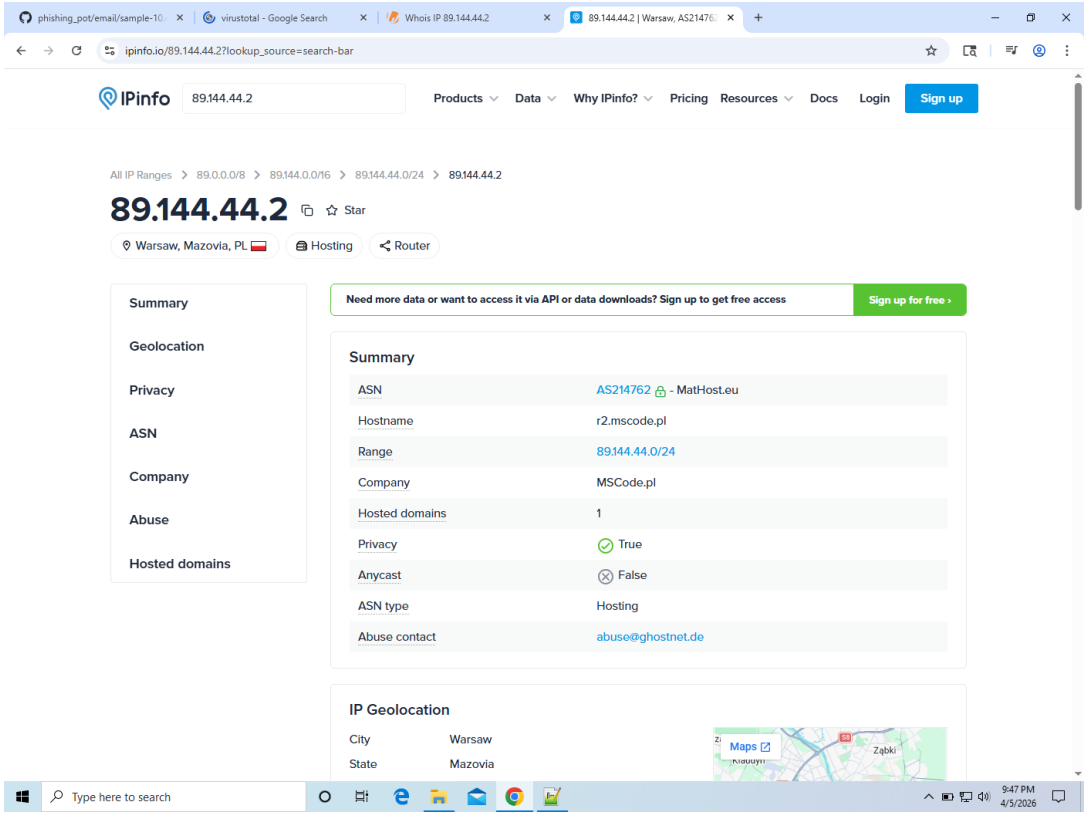

Figure 3 — IP geolocation and infrastructure information confirming non-Microsoft hosting

5. Email Content Analysis

5.1 Phishing Email Structure

The email mimics a legitimate Microsoft Account security notification. It claims an unusual login was detected from Moscow, Russia and pressures the victim to take immediate action by clicking a "Report the user" button that links to the phishing domain.

Email Element	Analysis
Email design	Copies Microsoft Account security email template exactly
Claimed event	Unusual sign-in activity from Moscow, Russia
Action demanded	Click "Report the user" button
Link destination	http://thebandalisty.com/track/... — malicious
Microsoft branding	Uses Microsoft logo, fonts and colour scheme
Sender legitimacy	Unknown — would require full header analysis to confirm
Content goal	Trick victim into clicking link to harvest credentials

5.2 Finding #5 — Psychological Manipulation

The email is expertly crafted to exploit human psychology. The combination of fear (unauthorised access), urgency (act now), and authority (Microsoft) creates a powerful emotional pressure that bypasses rational analysis:

- FEAR: "Someone from Russia accessed your account" — victim panics
- URGENCY: "Immediate action required" — victim feels no time to think
- AUTHORITY: "Microsoft Security Team" — victim trusts the source
- CONSEQUENCE: Implied account loss if action not taken immediately
- FALSE SAFETY: "Report the user" sounds like a protective action — not a threat

5.3 Screenshot Evidence — Email Content

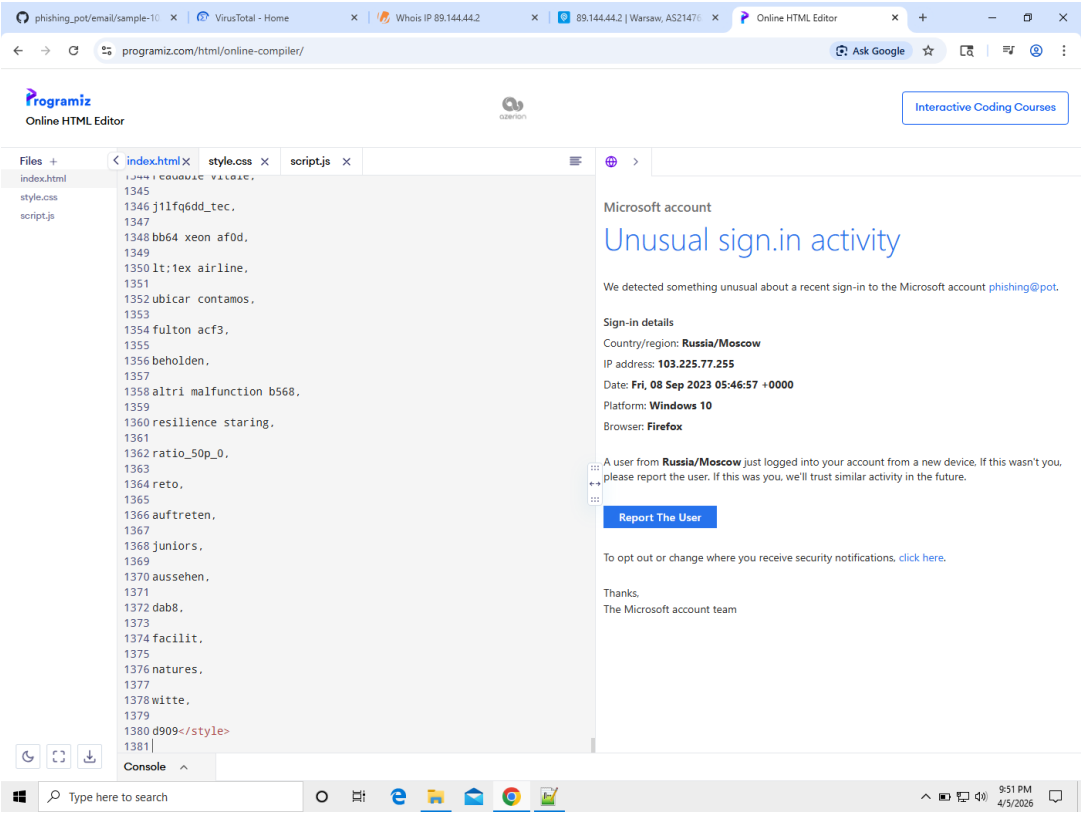

Figure 4 — Phishing email HTML showing Microsoft impersonation, fake Russia login alert and malicious "Report the user" button

6. MITRE ATT&CK Framework Mapping

All identified attack techniques have been mapped to the MITRE ATT&CK framework — the industry standard used by SOC analysts to classify and communicate cyber threats.

Technique ID	Technique Name	Description	Evidence in Email
T1566.001	Spearphishing Link	Email containing malicious link	Report the user button → thebandalisty.com
T1598.003	Phishing for Information	Harvesting credentials via fake portal	Tracking URL → credential page
T1204.001	User Execution: Malicious Link	Victim must click to activate attack	"Report the user" CTA button
T1036.005	Masquerading: Match Legit Name	Impersonating Microsoft brand	Exact Microsoft email template copy
T1056.003	Web Portal Capture	Fake login form captures credentials	thebandalisty.com landing page
T1598	Phishing for Information	Fear-based social engineering	Moscow login claim — false urgency

7. Indicators of Compromise (IOCs)

The following IOCs can be used to detect and block this phishing campaign in security tools, firewalls, email gateways and SIEM rules.

IOC Type	Value	Tool Used to Identify
IP Address	89.144.44.2	WHOIS + IP-API lookup
Hosting Provider	MSCode sp. z o.o. — Warsaw, Poland	WHOIS lookup
Phishing Domain	thebandalisty.com	VirusTotal + URL extraction
Phishing URL Path	/track/	Email body URL analysis
Protocol anomaly	HTTP (not HTTPS) for Microsoft link	URL analysis
Email subject	Microsoft Account - Unusual Sign-in Activity	Email subject line
Impersonated brand	Microsoft Account Security Team	Email content analysis
Social eng. trigger	Moscow/Russia login location	Email content analysis
VirusTotal detections	9/95 vendors flagged malicious	VirusTotal scan

8. Recommendations

8.1 Immediate Blocking Actions

Block these immediately across all security controls to stop further victims from this campaign.

1. Block IP address 89.144.44.2 at the firewall and email security gateway
2. Block domain thebandalisty.com at DNS resolver and web proxy
3. Block all HTTP traffic to thebandalisty.com/track/* URL pattern
4. Submit IP 89.144.44.2 to AbuseIPDB with full report details
5. Report phishing URL to Microsoft at phish@office365.microsoft.com
6. Report to VirusTotal and Google Safe Browsing for faster global blocking

8.4 Long-Term Security Improvements

- Enable Multi-Factor Authentication (MFA) on all Microsoft accounts — even if credentials are stolen, MFA blocks access
- Deploy Microsoft Defender for Office 365 — it automatically detects brand impersonation
- Run phishing simulation campaigns quarterly to test user awareness
- Configure DMARC p=reject policy on all company domains to prevent domain spoofing

9. Final Conclusion

Based on comprehensive multi-tool investigation across URL reputation, IP infrastructure, email content and social engineering analysis, this email is conclusively confirmed as a high-risk phishing attack designed to steal Microsoft account credentials.

Finding	Verdict
Brand impersonation	CONFIRMED — exact Microsoft email template copied
Social engineering	CONFIRMED — fear + urgency + authority impersonation
Phishing URL	CONFIRMED — thebandalisty.com has zero Microsoft connection
VirusTotal detection	CONFIRMED — 9/95 vendors flagged as malicious
IP infrastructure	SUSPICIOUS — Warsaw Poland server, not Microsoft
HTTP protocol	RED FLAG — real Microsoft uses HTTPS only
MITRE techniques	6 techniques mapped — T1566, T1598, T1204, T1036, T1056
IOCs documented	9 indicators of compromise identified and documented

FINAL RISK LEVEL: HIGH — CONFIRMED PHISHING ATTACK

End of Report — Phishing Investigation PHISH-2026-002 — Analyst: Amit Pal